project.org

STUDENT HANDOUT

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Bearing True Witness

Grades 5–8 · Religion

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

01 PART 1 — The Moral Dimension of Truth

> *Jesus said to him, 'I am the way, and the truth, and the life.'*
>
> JOHN 14:6

For Christians, truth is not merely factual accuracy — it is a Person. Jesus identifies himself AS truth. This means our commitment to truthfulness is inseparable from our commitment to Christ. Every act of deception distances us from the One who is Truth itself.

02 PART 2 — Catechism Deep Dive

The Catechism addresses truth in paragraphs 2464–2513. Key teachings:

- **CCC 2475–2476:** Respect for reputation forbids "rash judgment, detraction, and calumny"
- **CCC 2489:** We must balance truth with charity — not all true things should be shared
- **CCC 2497:** Information must serve the common good and respect justice and charity

Reflection: How does the teaching that "not all true things should be shared" balance with the call to bear true witness?

03 PART 3 — Research: Witnesses to Truth

Throughout history, Catholics have shown moral courage by bearing witness to truth despite persecution. Research ONE:

- **St. Thomas More** — Executed for refusing to lie about the king's marriage
- **St. Maximilian Kolbe** — Journalist who used media to spread truth, died at Auschwitz
- **Blessed Franz Jägerstätter** — Austrian who refused to swear a false oath to Hitler

- **St. Oscar Romero** — Archbishop who spoke truth to power despite death threats

Person researched: _____

What truth did they witness to?	What did it cost them?	What can we learn from their example today?

PART 4

04 Theological Question

Spirit photographers created false images; deepfake creators do the same with video. Both exploit trust in visual "evidence."

Question: The Catechism speaks of sins against truth including "false witness, perjury, detraction, calumny, boasting, and irony meant to harm." In our digital age, should "creating or sharing manipulated media" be understood as a distinct offense against truth? Why or why not?

MINI MUSEUM DEEP DIVE

William Mumler was put on trial for fraud in 1869 but was acquitted — not because he was innocent, but because the prosecution couldn't prove HOW he faked the photos.

Reflect: When technology makes deception undetectable, how does our moral responsibility change?

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving

PART 5

05 Modern Application

The Catechism (CCC 2494) states: "Information provided by the media is at the service of the common good. Society has a right to information based on truth, freedom, justice, and solidarity."

Question: What responsibilities do we have as consumers AND sharers of information in the digital age?

SHARE WITH YOUR FAMILY

Discussion: Share what you learned about a Catholic witness to truth. Discuss as a family: What truths might require courage to witness in our world today?